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A Transition Course Supporting Student Veterans' Success

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A Transition Course Supporting Student Veterans' Success

by

Caitlin Burnett

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Master's Project

Submitted to the College of Education

And Community Innovation

At Grand Valley State University

In partial fulfillment of the

Degree of Master of Education



The signatures of the individuals below indicate that they have read and approved the project of **Caitlin Burnett** in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of **M.Ed in Higher Education, College Student Affairs Leadership**

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Caitlin Burnett

Abstract

Research has shown that student veterans face unique challenges when transitioning from military service to college, yet many higher education institutions, including Grand Valley State University, have not developed targeted support systems to meet their specific needs. This project explores the experiences of student veterans in higher education and identifies important strategies that promote a successful transition to academic life. A thorough support program must acknowledge the complexity of this transition, including the cultural shift from military to civilian life, and must address academic, personal, and professional development. The Veteran Transition Course is designed to support student veterans in building a strong foundation for college success. It includes intentional content focused on time management, translating military experience into academic strengths, connecting with campus resources, and help develop a sense of belonging. In addition, the course encourages reflection and goal setting. This course balances the need for academic preparation with the importance of community-building and identity development, empowering veterans to take ownership of their college experience and future career paths.

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Chapter One: Introduction

Problem Statement

Student veterans often encounter distinct challenges when transitioning to college, including difficulties navigating academic systems, adjusting to campus culture, and managing mental health concerns (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Yeager, 2022). These factors can significantly impact their academic success and overall well-being (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Yeager, 2022). Hunter-Johnson et al., (2021) highlight the nuances of these challenges, particularly the hidden issues that may not be immediately apparent to educators or administrators. Hunter-Johnson et al. (2021) discuss how veterans often struggle with the shift from a highly structured military environment to the more independent and flexible nature of higher education. This transition can lead to feelings of isolation, difficulty relating to traditional students, and frustration with unstructured academic expectations (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021). Additionally, Barmak et al., (2023) emphasizes the importance of creating a veteran-friendly learning environment where faculty and staff understand these underlying struggles and actively work to lessen them. For instance, veterans may be hesitant to ask for accommodations or support due to a military mindset that values self-sufficiency, making it necessary for institutions to proactively offer tailored resources and build a culture of support.

Vest et al. (2024) further illustrate the complexity of student veterans' experiences, noting that while some veterans seek recognition and acknowledgement of their service, other prefer to blend in with the general student population. This contrast presents a challenge for institutions striving to support veterans without making them feel singled out. One example of this difficulty is the way veterans engage with campus resources—some may actively seek out veteran specific services, while others avoid them due to concerns about stigma or a desire for normalcy (Barmak

et al., 2023). Additionally, veterans may find it challenging to connect with traditional students, who may not fully understand their experiences, leading to social isolation and difficulty building a support network on campus (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Vest et al., 2024; Yeager, 2022).

Mental health is another factor affecting student veterans' academic performance (Hinkson et al., 2022). Hinkson et al. (2022) examine the relationship between mental health conditions such as PTSD and depression and their impact on veterans' educational outcomes. Many veterans experience difficulty concentrating, increased stress levels, and emotional challenges that interfere with their ability to succeed academically (Hinkson et al., 2022). Traditional academic support services may not fully address these needs, highlighting the necessity for targeted interventions that incorporate mental health resources (Barmak et al., 2023; Hinkson et al., 2022).

This project seeks to address these divides by designing a transition course specifically for veteran students, incorporating evidence-based practices that align with the principles of holistic student development. The course will directly address the hidden issues highlighted in the literature by offering structured support for academic preparedness, social integration, and mental health resilience. For example, it will include modules that help veterans navigate academic expectations, develop time management and study skills, and build confidence in engaging with faculty and peers. Additionally, the course will incorporate discussions on identity and belonging, helping veterans navigate the tension between seeking visibility and maintaining their independence. Mental health resources will also be embedded into the curriculum, ensuring that veterans have access to the tools they need to manage stress, anxiety, and PTSD symptoms in an academic setting. By taking a comprehensive approach, this project aims to create a

supportive learning environment that acknowledges the complexities of veterans' experiences while equipping them with the skills necessary to thrive in college.

Importance and Rationale of the Project

Unlike traditional students, veterans must navigate a complex shift from a highly structured and disciplined military environment to the more autonomous and flexible nature of college life (Griffin & Gilbert, 2015). This transition often results in difficulties adapting to academic expectations, feelings of social isolation, and struggles with mental health conditions such as PTSD, anxiety, and depression (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Yeager, 2022). Without targeted support systems in place, these challenges can interfere with veterans' ability to continue and succeed in college, leading to lower academic performance and unmet potential (Barmak et al., 2023; Griffin & Gilbert, 2015).

Many veterans feel disconnected from their peers due to differences in age, life experience, and priorities (Vest et al., 2024). Traditional college students may not fully understand the military experience, leaving veterans without a sense of belonging on campus (Vest et al., 2024). Additionally, navigating academic systems can be particularly difficult for veterans who have been out of an academic setting for years and may be unfamiliar with modern educational expectations, such as online learning platforms, research-based coursework, and self-directed study habits (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Vest et al., 2024). Mental health concerns further compound these challenges as veterans dealing with PTSD, depression, or anxiety may struggle to focus, manage stress, or seek help due to the ingrained military mindset of self-resilience (Hinkson et al., 2022).

Failure to address these issues can lead to negative outcomes, such as disengagement from coursework, difficulty forming peer connections, and, ultimately, dropping out of college (Yeager, 2022). Hunter-Johnson et al., (2021) has displayed that institutions that provide structured support for student veterans see higher retention and graduation rates among this population. Recognizing these barriers, this project wants to develop a transition course specifically designed to address the unique needs of student veterans. This course will offer guidance on academic preparedness, helping veterans understand college expectations, improve study skills, and navigate campus resources. Additionally, it will encourage social integration by creating opportunities for veterans to connect with peers, faculty, and support staff who understand their experiences. Finally, mental health and resilience training will be integrated withing the course, ensuring that veterans have access to coping strategies and professional support when needed.

Background of the Project

The transition from military service to higher education is often marked by a significant disconnect between the structured nature of military life and the more independent, self-directed academic culture of colleges and universities (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Yeager, 2022). Hunter-Johnson et al. (2021) highlight this disconnect, emphasizing that veterans frequently struggle to adapt to the less regimented environment of higher education, where expectations for time management, self-advocacy, and independent learning differ greatly from the military's structured routines. For many veterans, the shift from a mission-oriented approach, where orders and objectives are clearly defined, to a college setting that requires self-regulation and personal initiative can be overwhelming (Griffin & Gilbert, 2015). Additionally, military training often emphasizes practical, hands-on learning, whereas higher education typically relies on knowledge

and abstract problem-solving, creating further barriers to academic success (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021).

Beyond academic challenges, veterans may also face difficulties integrating into campus culture. Traditional college students, many of whom are younger and have limited exposure to military life, may struggle to relate to veteran students' experiences (Vest, 2024). This can lead to feelings of social isolation, as veterans often find themselves disconnected from their peers. Furthermore, campus policies and procedures may not always align with the needs of veterans, who may have service-related disabilities, financial constraints, or family obligations that make navigating higher education more complex (Barmak et al., 2023).

Recognizing these barriers, institutions have made efforts to implement veteran-specific support services, such as dedicated resource centers and orientation programs (Barmak et al., 2023). While these initiatives provide important resources, they often fall short of offering structured academic and social transition support (Barmak et al., 2023). Many programs focus on logistical assistance, such as benefits of counseling and academic advising, without addressing the broader cultural and psychological adjustments that veterans must make (Barmak et al., 2023; Vest et al., 2024). Griffin & Gilbert (2015) highlight the need for a comprehensive transition curriculum tailored to veteran students, ensuring they have the tools and support necessary to bridge the divide between military and academic life.

Statement of Purpose

The purpose of this project is to develop a structured, 8-week long transition course specifically designed for veteran students entering college. This course will focus on academic preparation, social integration, and mental health support, directly addressing the unique

challenges veteran students face as they transition from military to academic life. The course will be a 1 credit class that meets once a week for 75 minutes. It will be offered in multiple formats, primarily in-person to foster peer connections and engagement, but with an online or hybrid option to accommodate veterans with work or family obligations.

The ideal time for students to take this course would be during their first semester of enrollment, ensuring they receive structured support from the beginning of their college experience. It will be taught by faculty or staff with expertise in veteran affairs, student success coaching, or counseling, ideally individuals who have either military experience or a strong background in working with veteran students. Guest speakers from campus veteran resource centers, mental health professionals, and career services will be incorporated to provide additional support and resources.

Objectives of the Project

The primary objective of this project is to develop a veteran-specific transition course curriculum that directly addresses the academic, social, and emotional challenges faced by student veterans. This curriculum will be designed to provide targeted support, ensuring that veterans have the necessary tools to successfully navigate their college experience. An important focus of the course will be promoting academic skills and preparedness, as many veterans transition from a highly structured military environment and may not have extensive experience with modern academic practices such as research, writing, and time management. By incorporating structured lessons and hands-on activities, the course will help close the divide and equip veterans with the skills needed to excel in higher education.

Another objective is to enhance social integration and peer connections. Many veterans feel isolated on campus due to differences in age, experience, and priorities compared to traditional students. The course will include opportunities for veterans to connect with one another, form social networks, and engage with faculty and staff who understand their unique experiences. Additionally, the course will provide mental health and resilience resources to support veterans who may be facing challenges such as PTSD, anxiety, or depression. By integrating mental health education, stress management strategies, and access to campus and community resources, the course will promote overall well-being and academic persistence.

Definition of Terms

- Veteran Student
 - A student who has served in the U.S. Armed Forces and is now enrolled in a college or university, often transitioning from military to civilian life (Hinkson Jr et al., 2022).
- Transition Course
 - A structured, 1 credit bearing program designed to help students adapt to a new academic and social environment. For this project, it refers specifically to a course tailored to address the unique needs of veteran students transitioning to college (Dillard & Yu, 2018).
- Post-9/11 GI Bill
 - A federal program providing educational benefits to veterans who served after September 11, 2001, including tuition coverage, housing allowances, and access to career resources (Hunter-Johnson, 2021).
- Academic Preparedness

- The ability to engage with and succeed in college-level coursework, encompassing skills such as time management, writing, and effective study habits (Gosh et al., 2019).
- Social Integration
 - The process through which students develop a sense of belonging and connection to their college community, creating relationships with peers, faculty, and staff (Vest et al., 2024).
- Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
 - A mental health condition that can develop after exposure to traumatic events, characterized by symptoms such as anxiety and emotional stress (Hinkson Jr et al., 2022).
- Veteran Resource Center (VRC)
 - A campus facility that provides support services for veteran students (Barmak et al., 2023).
- Holistic Support
 - An approach to student services that addresses academic, social, emotional, and financial needs to promote overall success (Harris et al., 2024).
- Civilian Transition
 - The process of adapting from a structured military environment to the relatively unstructured nature of civilian and academic life (Griffin & Gilbert, 2015).

Scope of the Project

The scope of this project is focused on developing a curriculum for a veteran-specific transition course that directly addresses the academic, social, and mental health challenges faced

by veteran students as they enter college. This project will involve designing course content that provides structured support in these areas, establishing that veterans have access to the necessary resources and guidance to navigate their educational journey successfully. Additionally, the project will include a compilation of campus and external resources, such as academic advising and mental health services, to further support student veterans in their transition.

However, this project will not include the implementation or piloting of the course within a college setting. While an evaluation model will be proposed, the project will not extend to collecting data or analyzing student outcomes. Furthermore, the course will be specifically tailored to veteran students and will not explore the experiences or needs of other student populations.

Several factors beyond the control of this project may impact its adoption and success. The willingness of an institution to support and implement the course will depend on administrative priorities and the availability of resources. Additionally, the likelihood of running the course will be influenced by veteran enrollment numbers, as there is no guarantee that a sufficient number of students will participate. Resource availability, particularly in relation to mental health support, may also be uncertain on institutional funding. Finally, external challenges such as financial instability and family obligations could affect veterans' ability to engage with the course, highlighting the need for flexibility and additional institutional support to enhance student success.

Chapter Two: Literature Review

Introduction

Veteran students transitioning into higher education face unique challenges that can impact their academic success, social integration, and overall well-being (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Pease, 2021; Yeager, 2022). While institutions have made progress in providing resources such as veteran resource centers and financial aid through the Post-9/11 GI Bill, there remains a gap in structured, curriculum-based support tailored to their specific needs (Harris et al., 2024; Morris et al., 2022; Stevenson & Le Buhn, 2020). This project seeks to address this gap by developing a veteran-specific transition course designed to ease their adjustment to college life.

This literature review examines important areas relevant to veteran student transitions in higher education. First, it explores the historical context of veteran education benefits and policies, highlighting how support structures have evolved. Next, it reviews the challenges faced by veteran students, including academic preparedness, social reintegration, and mental health concerns. The review then examines existing support models, including veteran resource centers, mentorship programs, and transition courses, assessing their effectiveness and identifying disconnections in current programming. Finally, best practices in curriculum design for adult learners, particularly those with military backgrounds, are explored to inform the development of the proposed course.

Theory/Rationale

Tinto's Theory of Student Integration

Tinto's (1993) theory of student integration suggests that students are more likely to keep going in higher education when they feel academically and socially integrated into their

institution. According to Meiners (2019), successful retention efforts must focus on certain opportunities for students to engage meaningfully with faculty, peers, and institutional resources. When students develop a sense of belonging and perceive themselves as valued members of their academic community, they are more likely to continue and successfully complete their degrees (Barry et al., 2021; Morris et al., 2022).

For veteran students, social integration is often one of the most significant challenges (Sokurianska et al., 2021). Unlike traditional students who often enter college directly from high school, veterans bring with them years of structured military training, leadership experience, and often a family to support (Kauer & Houser, 2023). As one can assume, these factors could lead to feelings of isolation, disengagement, and difficult navigating the informal social structures of a university setting. Without a strong peer network, veterans may lack the informal support systems that traditional students naturally develop through residence halls, student organizations, and first-year experiences (Sullivan et al., 2021).

To enhance social integration for veterans, institutions could create intentional programming and support systems that develop connections among veteran students and between veterans and the broader campus community. Establishing veteran-specific student organizations, mentoring programs that pair new veteran students with experienced peers and dedicated veteran lounges or centers can help create spaces where veterans feel understood and supported (Pease, 2021). Additionally, faculty and staff training on military culture, such as understanding the impact of service-related trauma, the importance of using respectful language when referring to military experience, and significance of rank and hierarchy, can improve institutional awareness, ensuring that veterans feel acknowledged and valued within the campus (Kauer & Houser, 2023; Morris et al., 2022).

Academic integration is another vital factor of Tinto's (1993) framework that applies to veteran students. According to Hunter-Johnson et al. (2021) many veterans have spent years outside of a formal academic setting and may struggle with college-level coursework, time management, and study skills. Unlike traditional students, whose recent experience in structured classroom settings provides continuity in their academic journey, veterans must often shift themselves to self-directed learning, critical thinking, and complex writing tasks (Sullivan et al., 2021). Additionally, the transition from highly regimented military structure to the relatively flexible and vague nature of higher education can be disorientating, making it difficult for veterans to navigate course expectations and academic policies (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Kauer & Houser, 2023).

Without effective academic support, veterans may experience difficulties adapting to the demands of higher education, leading to frustration, self-doubt, and potential withdrawal (Hammond, 2016). Tinto's (1993) model reinforces the necessity of structured academic engagement, faculty mentorship, and access to academic resources as components in improving retention and success for veterans. Institutions can support academic integration by implementing veteran-specific orientation programs, customized academic coaching or tutoring services, and faculty-led mentorship initiatives that recognize the unique strengths and challenges of veteran learners (Pease, 2021).

Knowles' Theory of Andragogy

Knowles' et al., (2011) developed the theory of andragogy to explain how adult learners differ from younger students and require distinct educational approaches. Knowles' et al., (2011) identified several principles that define adult learning, including self-direction, the use of prior experiences, goal orientation, and the need for immediate application of knowledge. These

principles are particularly relevant to veteran students, who enter college with unique life experiences and practical skills that traditional academic methods may not fully acknowledge (Blaauw-hara, 2017).

Veteran students bring with them years of structured discipline, leadership experience, and strong sense of autonomy developed through military service (Valenstein et al., 2022). Veterans are often highly self-directed learners who prefer problem-solving approaches to passive learning (Blaauw-hara, 2017). Unlike traditional students who may rely on instructors to structure their learning experiences, veterans tend to be motivated by personal and professional goals (Valenstein et al., 2022). Knowles' et al., (2011) suggests that educational models should allow for flexibility, acknowledge prior experiences, and focus on real-world applications to be most effective for adult learners.

A component of andragogy is the recognition that adults learn best when they can integrate new knowledge with their prior experiences (Blaauw-hara, 2017). Veterans often have specialized training in areas such as leadership, logistics, crisis management, and technical skills, which can be valuable skills in an academic setting (Valenstein et al., 2022). However, traditional college curriculum frequently does not account for these prior learning experiences, requiring veterans to start from scratch rather than building upon their existing skills (Sullivan et al., 2021). Institutions that incorporate credit for prior learning, experiential learning opportunities, and competency-based education can create a more effective pathways for veteran student success (Stevenson & Le Buhn, 2020). By leveraging their existing knowledge and skills, veterans could engage in more meaningful learning experiences that feel relevant and applicable to their career goals.

Blaauw-hara (2017) emphasizes that adult learners, including veterans, are goal-oriented and need to understand the immediate relevance of their education. Many veterans might pursue higher education with clear career aspirations, often seeking degrees that will help them transition into civilian job markets or advance in their professional fields. Unlike traditional students who may explore various academic interests before settling on a major, veterans tend to approach education with a strong sense of purpose (Valenstein et al., 2022).. This makes it pressing for institutions to offer academic advising, career counseling, and degree pathways that align with veterans' professional goals (Barmak et al., 2023).

Schlossberg's Transition Theory

Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory provides a psychological foundation for understanding how individuals experience life changes and the factors that influence their ability to adapt. Schlossberg (1981) defines a transition as any event or non-event that results in a change in relationships, routines, assumptions, and roles. This theory is particularly relevant to veteran students, as their transition from military to civilian and academic life is one of the most significant shifts they will experience (Griffin & Gilbert, 2015; Pedersen & Wieser, 2024). Moving from a highly structured environment into the relatively unstructured and independent setting of higher education presents both challenges and opportunities for veterans (Barmak et al., 2023).

Situation

For veterans, the transition to higher education may be influenced by factors such as discharge status, access to benefits (e.g. the GI Bill), family obligations, and personal motivations for returning to school (Lewis & Wu, 2021). Some veterans may have planned for

their transition into college well in advance, while others may find themselves entering college due to unexpected circumstances, such as medical discharge or difficulty finding employment after service.

Additionally, the shift from military service to academic life represents a fundamental change in structure and purpose (Hammond, 2016; Pederson & Wieser, 2024). In the military, daily life is highly regimented, with clear expectations, immediate feedback, and a strong sense of camaraderie (Harris et al., 2024). In contrast, higher education requires self-motivation, independent decision-making, and an ability to navigate ambiguous academic and social expectations (Lewis & Wu, 2021). Veterans who struggle to adjust to this new environment may experience frustrations, uncertainty, or even withdrawal from their academic pursuits (Lewis & Wu, 2021).

Self

Personal characteristics, including resilience, self-efficacy, and previous experiences with change, play a significant role in how individuals manage transitions (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021). Veterans often bring strengths such as discipline, leadership, teamwork, and problem-solving abilities, all of which can be assets in an academic setting (Yeager, 2022). However, they may also encounter challenges related to mental health, physical injuries, or identity shifts as they transition out of their military roles (Vest, et al., 2024).

For many veterans, leaving the military can mean a loss of a strong personal identity tied to their service (Wedham et al., 2024). In the military, their roles were clearly defined, their contributions were valued, and their mission was clear (Vest et al., 2024; Wedham et al., 2024). Entering college can create a sense of displacement as they work to redefine themselves outside

of the armed forces (Sullivan et al., 2021). Some may struggle with imposter syndrome, questioning whether they belong in an academic setting, particularly if they have been out of school for many years (Meiners, 2019). Others may feel disconnected from traditional college students, whose experiences and perspectives often differ greatly from their own.

Support

The availability of social and institutional support networks significantly impacts a veteran's transition experience (Barmak et al., 2023). Sullivan et al., (2021) suggested that veterans who have a strong support system- whether from family, friends, faculty, or campus resources- are more likely to continue in their academic journey. Conversely, those who feel isolated or lack access to appropriate support may struggle with disengagement (Sullivan et al., 2021).

Many veterans face challenges in connecting with traditional college students, who may not understand their experiences or perspectives (Valenstein et al., 2022). Sokurianska et al., (2021) established that this can lead to feelings of isolation and difficulty in forming peer relationships. Establishing veteran-specific student organizations, peer mentorship programs, and dedicated veteran lounges or resource centers can provide veterans with a sense of community and belonging (Semer & Harmening, 2015).

Strategies

Coping mechanisms and problem-solving approaches are essential for managing change successfully (Hinkson et al., 2022). Veterans who develop proactive strategies for navigating their new academic environment are more likely to persist and succeed in higher education (Lewis & Wu, 2021). These strategies may include time management techniques, study skills,

and utilization of campus resources such as tutoring centers, writing labs, and academic coaching.

One challenge veteran often face is adapting to the relative flexibility of college life compared to the rigid structure of military training (Blaauw-Hara, 2017). The self-directed nature of higher education requires strong executive functioning skills, which some veterans may need to refine (Blaauw-Hara, 2017). Universities can support this transition by offering workshops on academic skills, time management, and goal setting specifically designed for veteran students.

According to Ghosh et al., (2019), another strategy involves leveraging prior military experiences to enhance academic success. Veterans are used to working in high-pressure environments, managing complex tasks, and collaborating with diverse teams- skills that can translate effectively into the classroom (Semer & Harmening, 2015). Encouraging veterans to view their military background as a strength rather than a limitation can help them approach their education with greater confidence and motivation (Meiners, 2019).

Together, Tinto's (1993) theory of student integration, Knowles' et al., (2011) theory of andragogy, and Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory provide an in-depth framework for understanding the unique challenges veteran students face in higher education and the strategies that can support their success. Tinto's (1993) theory highlights the importance of academic and social integration, emphasizing the need for the institutions to create structured opportunities for veterans to build connections and engage with their academic community. Knowles' et al., (2011) theory reinforces the need for adult learning models that acknowledge veterans' prior experiences, self-directed learning styles, and goal-oriented approach to education (Blaauw-hara, 2017).. Meanwhile, Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory provides insight into how veterans navigate the shift from military to civilian academic life, with key factors such as personal

resilience, support systems, and coping strategies playing a significant role in their transition experience. By applying these theories, institutions can help develop intentional programming, support networks, and academic initiatives that encourage veteran student success, ultimately promoting a more inclusive and supportive higher education environment.

Research/Evaluation

Historical Context of Veteran Education and Support Structures

Veteran education policies have expanded significantly over time, shaped by legislative and institutional responses to the unique needs of service members transitioning to civilian life (Lewis & Houser, 2021). The Servicemen's Readjustment Act of 1944 (GI Bill) provided access to higher education for World War II veterans, leading to an expansion of university enrollments and development of policies supporting nontraditional students (Morris et al., 2022). Subsequent amendments, including the Post-9/11 GI Bill, have further refined educational benefits, addressing financial barriers but not always the structural and cultural challenges veterans face in higher education (Morris et al., 2022).

Sokurianska et al., (2021) indicates that despite the availability of financial aid, many veterans encounter difficulties navigating institutional processes, balancing academic responsibilities with work and family, and reintegrating into civilian peer groups. Institutions have developed various veteran-specific support services, such as academic advising personalized to military experiences and mental health resources, but their effectiveness varies based on implementation and institutional commitment (Barmak et al., 2023; Stevenson & Le Buhn, 2020). Tinto's (1993) student integration model suggests that both academic and social

integration are key to student persistence, which highlights the importance of targeted institutional support structures for veterans (Morris et al., 2022; Teixeira, 2021).

Challenges Faced by Veteran Students

Academic Preparedness and Adjustments

Veteran students often face difficulties in adapting to academic expectations, particularly after extended periods away from formal education (Lewis & Wu, 2021). Sullivan et al., (2021) found that military training emphasizes structured learning and direct application of skills, which can contrast with the more theoretical and self-directed nature of higher education. Common challenges include lower confidence in academic skills, difficulty with time management, and unfamiliarity with campus resources designed to support student success (Teixeira, 2021). Knowles' et al., (2011) adult learning theory highlights the importance of self-directed learning and experiential knowledge, suggesting that veteran students may benefit from academic structures that acknowledge and build upon their prior experiences.

Social Integration and Campus Climate

The transition from military service to higher education is not solely academic but also social (Lewis & Wu, 2021; Morris et al., 2022). Veterans often struggle with feeling isolated from their civilian peers due to differences in age, life experiences, and personal responsibilities (Lewis & Wu, 2021; Morris et al., 2022; Sokurianska et al., 2021). Unlike traditional students, many veterans are married, have children, or maintain employment while attending college, adding additional complexity to their social and academic integration (Kauer & Houser, 2023). A lack of understanding from faculty and peers regarding military culture can further contribute to feelings of separation, highlighting the need for targeted peer support programs and faculty

training on veteran-related issues (Dillard & Yu, 2018). Tinto's (1993) theory of integration emphasizes the significance of social belonging in student retention, further reinforcing the need for structured peer networks and inclusive campus environments for veterans.

Mental Health and Well-Being

Hinkson et al., (2022); Valenstein et al., (2022) highlights the mental health challenges veteran students face, including post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), depression, and anxiety. Some can assume that the transition from military to civilian life can be stressful, and for many veterans, these mental health concerns are compounded by academic stressors. Universities with well-established mental health support systems, including counseling services specifically designed for veterans, demonstrate higher retention and success rates among this population (Harris et al., 2024). However, stigma surrounding mental health services remains a barrier to seeking help, requiring institutions to adopt proactive outreach strategies (Barmak et al., 2023; Yeager, 2022). Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory provides a useful perspective for understanding these challenges, emphasizing the role of institutional and social support in helping individuals navigate major life transitions, including the shift from military to academic life.

Existing Support Models for Veteran Students

Veteran Resource Centers and Institutional Support

Veteran resource centers (VRCs) have become a central element of institutional efforts to support veteran students (Barmak et al., 2023; Semer & Harmening, 2015). These centers provide a range of services, including academic advising, career counseling, and access to mental health resources (Barmak et al., 2023). Stevenson & Le Buhn (2020) indicate that university with

well-funded and integrated VRCs report higher retention and graduation rates among veterans. However, inconsistencies in funding and institutional buy-in create disparities in the quality of services available across institutions (Harris et al., 2024). Tinto's (1993) student integration model stresses the role of institutional commitment in promoting student persistence, suggesting that VRCs are most effective when fully integrated into the broader university support network.

Mentorship and Peer Support Programs

Peer mentorship programs have been identified as a particularly effective means of support veteran students during their transition to higher education (Pease, 2021). Valenstein et al., (2022) suggest that connecting incoming veteran students with more experienced peers who have successfully navigated the college experience can significantly enhance academic persistence and social integration. Formalized mentorship programs that include structured meetings, goal-setting initiatives, and faculty involvement tend to yield the most positive outcomes (Pease, 2021). Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory reinforces the importance of mentorship, as strong support networks can help veterans develop a sense of belonging and confidence in their new academic environment.

Best Practices in Curriculum Design for Veteran Students

Adult Learning Strategies

Dillard & Yu (2018) researched on best practices in adult education stressing the importance of learner-centered approaches that acknowledge and build upon students' prior experiences. Veteran students, in particular, benefit from curriculum structures that incorporate real-world application, experimental learning, and collaborative problem-solving exercises (Dillard & Yu, 2018). Integrating flexible learning formats, such as hybrid and online courses,

has also been shown to enhance engagement and academic success among veterans who may have work or family commitments (Dillard & Yu, 2018; Ghosh et al., 2019). Knowles' et al., (2011) adult learning theory supports these findings, emphasizing that adult learners thrive when education is relevant to their experiences and allows for self-direction.

Career Readiness and Transition Preparedness

Many veterans pursue higher education as a means of advancing their careers, making career readiness an important component of veteran support initiatives (Meiners, 2019). (Ghosh et al., 2019) suggests that institutions that offer individualized career services—such as translating military experience into civilian job qualifications, networking opportunities, and targeted internships—experience higher employment outcomes for veteran graduates. Collaborative effort between universities and employers to develop veteran-friendly hiring pipelines further enhance post-graduation success rates (Ghosh et al., 2019; Sullivan et al., 2021). Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory is particularly relevant here, as it highlights the need for structured institutional support to ease the transition from military service to civilian employment.

Summary

Veteran students transitioning into higher education face unique challenges that impact their academic success, social integration, and overall well-being (Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Pease, 2021; Yeager, 2022). While financial support such as the Post-9/11 GI Bil has improved access to higher education, veterans often struggle with academic preparedness, navigating campus life, and finding a sense of belonging (Ghosh et al., 2019; Morris et al., 2022). This project explores these challenges and evaluates existing support models, including veteran

resource centers, peer mentorship programs, and transition courses. Established in Tinto's (1993) theory of student integration, Knowles' et al., (2011) theory of andragogy, and Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory, this research underscores the importance of structured academic and social support for veterans. Best practices in curriculum design for adult learners are examined to inform the development of a veteran-specific transition course that facilitates their adjustment to higher education (Sullivan et al., 2021).

Conclusion

The literature reviewed emphasizes the necessity of targeted support programs for veteran students to improve retention, academic success, and social integration. While existing institutional resources provide valuable assistance, gaps remain in structured curriculum-based support customized to veterans' needs (Barmak et al., 2023; Blaauw-Hara, 2017). Implementing a veteran-specific transition course, informed by adult learning principles and best practices, can help fill this void by offering academic skill-building, social integration strategies, and career readiness support. By acknowledging the unique experiences of veteran students and leveraging their strengths, higher education institutions can create more inclusive environments that foster their success and long-term persistence (Vest et al., 2024).

Chapter 3: Project Description

Introduction

Student veterans face unique challenges when transitioning to college, including difficulties navigating academic systems, social integration, and mental health concerns such as PTSD and anxiety (Hinkson et al., 2022; Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021; Pease, 2021; Yeager, 2022). These obstacles interfere with their academic success and overall well-being, highlighting the need for targeted support (Teixeria, 2021). To address this issue, a veteran-specific transition course has been developed to strengthen academic preparedness, enhance social integration, and provide mental health and resilience resources. The course offers structured support tailored to the unique experiences of student veterans, assuring they have the tools necessary to thrive in a college environment.

Valenstein et al., (2022) emphasizes the importance of structured interventions that address both the institutional and social aspects of college life, especially for non-traditional students such as veterans. A veteran-specific transition course provides targeted support by helping student veterans develop crucial academic skills, connect with campus resources, and build a sense of belonging. Academic environments that promote community-building have been shown to improve student retention and success, especially for those undergoing major life transitions (Barmak et al., 2023; Harris et al., 2024). This chapter outlines the course details, learning objectives, and theoretical framework, drawing on evidence-based practices to ensure effectiveness. By incorporating Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory, Tinto's (1993) theory of student integration and Knowles' et al., (2011) theory of andragogy, the course narrows the divide between military and academic life. Through a focus on academic preparedness, social

integration, and mental health awareness, the course equips student veterans with the tools necessary for a successful transition to higher education.

Project Components

Course Description

The veteran transition course is an eight-week course offered during the second half of their first semester to the institution. This course is designed to support student veterans as they navigate the shift from military service to academic life, addressing the unique challenges they may face during this transition. Since the course is offered during the second half of the first semester, this timing allows student veterans to first experience the college environment independently before engaging in structured support. This approach makes sure that students have time to identify their challenges and can better apply the course material to their lived experiences (Dillard, 2018; Hunter-Johnson et al., 2021). With a focus on academic preparedness, social integration, and mental health resources, the course provides a structured yet flexible structure to help veterans build the skills and connections necessary for success in higher education. By offering a hybrid format with weekly 75-minute sessions, the course accommodates diverse schedules and learning preferences, ensuring accessibility for all participants.

Facilitated by staff from the university's Military and Veteran Resource Department with experience working with veterans, the course also features guest speakers, including campus resource representatives, mental health professionals, and veteran alumni, who provide specialized insights and strategies. Sessions are interactive, incorporating discussions, hands-on activities, and collaborative exercises to create an engaging and supportive learning environment.

The goal is to break down barriers between military and academic life while making sure that veterans have the tools and resources necessary to thrive in higher education.

The course is structured around areas essential for a successful transition. Academic preparedness will be a major focus, equipping student veterans with effective study strategies, time management techniques, and research skills adjusted to college expectations. Mental health awareness is also emphasized, providing resources and strategies to manage stress, PTSD, anxiety and other challenges that may impact academic success and personal well-being. Additionally, the course encourages social integration, helping veterans connect with their peers, faculty, and campus support systems to create a sense of belonging within the college environment.

Finally, the course emphasizes holistic success by addressing financial literacy, career planning, and goal setting. By exploring topics such as managing GI Bill benefits, developing career pathways, and setting personal and professional goals, veterans are empowered to take full advantage of their college experience. As an added incentive, student veterans who successfully complete all course requirements have their academic standing held for one semester, allowing them additional time to adjust to college life without immediate academic consequences. By the end of the course, student veterans feel more confident navigating their academic journey and utilizing the resources available to support their success.

Course Curriculum

Learning Outcomes

The learning outcomes for this course are grounded in Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory, Knowles' et al., (2011) theory of andragogy, and Tinto's (1993) theory of student

integration. These theories provide a foundation for understanding the challenge student veterans face in their transition to higher education. The learning outcomes for the course are as outlined below:

1. Students will be able to develop effective time management strategies to navigate college coursework successfully.
2. Students will be able to apply study techniques to improve academic performance.
3. Students will be able to demonstrate research skills by locating and evaluating academic sources.
4. Students will be able to identify and engage with key campus resources, including veteran support services, academic advising, mental health resources, and tutoring centers.
5. Students will be able to engage with at least one campus resource applicable to their academic or personal success
6. Students will be able to develop and implement coping strategies for managing stress, anxiety, or PTSD.
7. Students will be able to reflect on their strengths, challenges, and evolving identity in the transition from military to college life.
8. Students will be able to build meaningful peer connections to reduce social isolation and enhance their sense of belonging on campus.
9. Students will be able to establish an academic or career goal and identify steps to achieve it.
10. Students will be able to effectively manage their GI Bill benefits or financial aid by identifying important policies and available support.

11. Students will be able to apply problem-solving skills to navigate challenges in their transition to higher education.

Weekly Curriculum

Listed below are the weekly curriculum plans to achieve each learning outcome. This course is a 75-minute hybrid session held weekly over eight weeks. A sample of one of the course sessions will be included in Appendix A.

	Topics	Partners	Learning Outcomes	Class Format
Week 1: Navigating Your GI Bill & Financial Resources	Understanding GI Benefits, financial aid options, and funding strategies for academic success	Veteran Services Office & Financial Aid	10 & 11	In-Person
Week 2: Academic Success Strategies for Veterans	Developing effective study habits, time management, research strategies, and adjusting to college coursework	Student Success Center & Tutoring Center	1, 2 & 3	In-Person
Week 3: Mental Health, Stress Management, and Resilience	Understanding common mental health challenges among veterans (PTSD, anxiety, depression) and learning coping mechanisms	Counseling Services	6 & 7	Online
Week 4: Campus Resources & Student Support Services	Identifying key campus resources, including disability services, career services and student life offices.		4	Online
Week 5: Social Integration &	Addressing social isolation, creating	Student Life Office	8 & 4	Online

Community Building	peer connections, and getting involved in student organizations			
Week 6: Career Development & Professional Networking	Resume building, interview preparation, leveraging military experience for civilian careers, and networking opportunities.	Career Center	5 & 9	In-Person
Week 7: Identity Development, Imposter Syndrome & Self-Advocacy in Higher Education	Understanding personal identity beyond the military, addressing feelings of imposter syndrome, activating for accommodations and resources, and embracing personal and academic growth	Diversity, Equity & Inclusion Office	7 & 4	Online
Week 8: Reflection, Goal setting & Next Steps	Reflecting on the course experience, setting academic and career goals, and planning for continued success.		9 & 1	In-Person

Project Evaluation

Evaluating the effectiveness of this veteran-specific transition course is important to make sure it meets its intended learning outcomes and provides meaningful support for student veterans. A complete evaluation plan will incorporate both qualitative and quantitative methods to assess student engagement, learning process, and overall satisfaction. By gathering feedback at multiple points throughout the course, the evaluation process will help enhance the curriculum

and determine the program's long-term impact on student veterans' academic and personal success.

Course Grade

This course is a 1-credit course graded on a pass/fail basis to make sure both instructor compensation and student accountability. Assessing student engagement and participation is important to guarantee the effectiveness of the program. Course grading will be based on completion of assignments, participation in discussions and activities, and engagement with course materials rather than traditional exams or letter grades. Students will be evaluated on their contributions to weekly reflections, attendance and participation in both in-person and online sessions, and completion of self-assessments and surveys. These elements are designed to encourage active involvement and provide insights into students' progress in achieving the learning outcomes. By prioritizing participation and self-reflection, the grading structure supports a meaningful and personalized transition experience for student veterans.

	Assignments	Points
Week 1: Understanding the GI Bill and Financial Resources	Pre-Course Survey	10 points
Week 2: Academic Preparedness and Self-Regulated Learning	- Time Management & Study Skills Sheets - Weekly Reflection: Identifying Academic Strengths and Challenges	10 points 5 points
Week 3: Accessing and Utilizing Campus Resources	Campus Resource Scavenger Hunt Assignment	10 points
Week 4: Mental Health, Resilience, and Coping Strategies	- Wellness and Coping Plan Assignment - Weekly Reflection: Identifying Personal Resilience Strategies	10 points 5 points

Week 5: Social Integration and Building Community	Engagement Activity: Attend a Campus Event and Submit a Reflection	10 points
Week 6: Identity Development, Imposter Syndrome, and Self-Advocacy	Imposter Syndrome Reflection & Self-Advocacy Plan	10 points
Week 7: Career Readiness and Goal Setting	Personalized Career and Academic Goal Plan	10 points
Week 8: Course Wrap-up & Long-Term Success Strategies	- Post-Course Survey - Final Reflection: Personal Growth and Future Goals	10 points 5 points
Ongoing	Class Participation	15 points
		Total: 100 Points

Course Survey

To assess the effectiveness of this course, both of the pre-course and post-course survey are provided to measure student veterans' confidence, knowledge, and resource utilization before and after completing the program. The pre-course (Appendix B) forms baseline data on students' academic preparedness, familiarity with campus resources, and perceived challenges in their transition to college. The post-course survey (Appendix C) will be similar to the pre-course assessment, allowing for a comparison to evaluate growth in important areas such as academic confidence, social integration, and self-advocacy. These surveys include a combination of rating scale questions and open-ended responses to document both quantitative and qualitative findings. The results help determine the course's impact and identify areas for further development to better support future student veterans.

Long-Term Follow-Up

A long-term follow-up assessment is conducted to determine whether the course has a lasting impact on student veterans' academic performance, campus engagement, and overall dedication in higher education. To achieve this, a follow-up survey (Appendix D) is given three months after course completion to assess whether students continue to utilize the strategies and resources introduced during the program. Additionally, collaboration with academic advisors and veteran support staff helps track retention and success rates of course participants compared to non-participants. This follow-up assessment provides valuable information into the long-term effectiveness of the course and identifies any areas for improvement to better support future cohorts of student veterans.

Course Incentive

As an incentive for participation and completion, student veterans who successfully fulfill all course requirements have their academic standing held for one semester. This acknowledges the unique challenges veterans face during their transition to college, including adjusting to academic expectations, managing mental health concerns, and balancing external responsibilities. By temporarily safeguarding their academic standing, veterans have the opportunity to acclimate to the demands of higher education without the immediate pressure of academic probation or dismissal. This incentive encourages full engagement in the course, ensuring that student veterans actively develop the skills, connections, and resources needed to thrive throughout their college experience.

Project Conclusions

As highlighted in chapter one, student veterans often face unique challenges, including difficulties with academic preparedness, social integration, and mental health concerns (Barry et al., 2021; Morris et al., 2022; Yeager, 2022). Through a review of literature in chapter two, it became apparent that these challenges result from differences in learning styles, the need for institutional support, and the psychological adjustment required to transition from a highly structured military environment to the autonomy of higher education (Dillard & Yu, 2018; Gosh et al., 2019; Pederson & Wieser, 2024). Theories such as Schlossberg's (1981) transition theory, Knowles' et al., (2011) theory of andragogy, and Tinto's (1993) theory of student integration further reinforce the importance of targeted intervention that address these concerns through structured programming and institutional support.

The development of an eight-week veteran-specific transition course provides a strategic approach to addressing these barriers. The course is designed to develop academic success by supplying veterans with essential skills such as time management, study strategies, and resource navigation. Additionally, the inclusion of mental health and resilience-building elements acknowledges the impact of stress, PTSD, and other challenges on student success. Social integration strategies ingrained within the curriculum further strive to enhance veterans' sense of belonging and engagement with the campus community, an important factor in student retention and persistence. By incorporating a hybrid format and interactive learning methods, the course is structured to meet veterans where they are, making sure accessibility and practical application of course content.

Ultimately, this course highlights the necessity of institutional commitment to veteran student success through intentional programming and support services. Kauer & Houser (2023)

highlights that when veterans are provided with structured resources, peer support, and institutional guidance, they are more likely to persist and succeed in higher education. Furthermore, the incentive of holding academic standing for one semester reinforces this dedication to easing the transition process, reducing unnecessary academic stress, and creating long-term student success. The conclusions drawn from this research support the implementation of this transition course as an important component of veteran student services, with the potential to improve retention, engagement, and overall academic achievement among student veterans.

Plans for Implementation

The findings from this project provide a strong foundation for enhancing institutional support for student veterans, but additional steps can be taken to further refine and expand these efforts. Future research should explore long-term outcomes of veteran transition programs, including their impact on retention rates, academic performance, and overall well-being. Additionally, gathering qualitative feedback from student veterans who complete the course will help inform continuous improvements to the curriculum. To implement these findings, collaboration with academic advisors, veteran support services, and faculty members will be important to integrating this course into existing programming. Sharing this work through professional development workshops and campus-wide discussions will promote awareness and encourage best practices in supporting veteran students. Furthermore, developing partnerships with local and national veteran organizations can strengthen resources and advocacy efforts, ensuring that student veterans receive the holistic support they need to thrive in higher education.

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Appendix A

Sample Session Plan

This is a sample session for Week 2: Academic Success Strategies for Veterans, focusing on developing effective study habits, time management, research strategies, and adjusting to college coursework. This plan includes campus partners (Student Success Center & Tutoring Center) will come in to present.

Week 2: Academic Success Strategies for Veterans

- Focus: Developing effective study habits, time management, research strategies, and adjusting to coursework.
- Campus Partners: Student Success Center & Tutoring Center
- Learning Outcomes: 1, 2, & 3
- Format: In-Person Session

Session Overview

In this session, veterans will focus on strategies to enhance academic performance and adjust to the demands of college coursework. The session will include presentations from the Student Success Center and the Tutoring Center to provide veterans with the tools and support available on campus.

Session Plan

1. Welcome & Icebreaker (10 minutes)
 - Begin with a brief welcome and a quick icebreaker
 - Icebreaker idea: Ask students to share one tip they want to use for managing their academic workload
 - Overview of the session and objectives
2. Introduction to Academic Success Strategies (15 minutes)
 - Discuss the importance of time management, study habits, and adapting to the demands of college coursework
 - Introduce the concept of active learning and how veterans can implement this approach to improve retention and understanding course material
 - Mention the importance of building a schedule that includes both study and rest periods
 - Highlight strategies for self-motivation and creating an environment conducive to studying

3. Campus Partners Presentations (25 minutes)
 - Student Success Center (12 minutes)
 - Tutoring Center (13 minutes)
4. Group Activity: Time Management and Study Strategies (15 minutes)
 - Divide into small groups
 - Task: In their groups, veterans will discuss their current time management practices and study strategies. They will also explore new techniques introduced during the presentations
 - Deliverable: Each group creates a time-block study schedule for the upcoming week, factoring in class times and personal obligations
 - Purpose: Help students create realistic, sustainable study routines that align with their goals
5. Discussion: Adjusting to College Coursework (10 minutes)
 - Open the floor for discussion on the challenges veterans face in adjusting to college coursework
 - Prompt: Ask students to share their experiences with balancing coursework and other responsibilities
 - Use this time to clarify any common concerns about time management, staying on top of assignments, or approaching coursework from a difference academic background (military vs civilian)
6. Wrap-Up & Resources (5 minutes)
 - Summarize key takeaways from the session, emphasizing the importance of time management, study habits, and using campus resources
 - Provide handouts to the Student Success Center and Tutoring Center
 - Encourage students to schedule a meeting with a coach from the Student Success Center or book a session with the Tutoring Center if they feel they need additional support
 - Remind students of the next week's topic and resources available
7. Exit Ticket Assignment
 - Reflection Paper: Ask students to write a short reflection on how they plan to implement at least two new academic success strategies discussed during the session

Appendix B

Pre-Survey

This appendix consists of the pre survey that will be completed by veteran students who decide to participate in this course. This survey will assess student veterans' initial confidence, knowledge, and concerns related to academic success, social integration and mental health support before starting the course.

1. How confident do you feel about your ability to succeed academically?
 - ☐ Very confident
 - ☐ Somewhat confident
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat unconfident
 - ☐ Not confident at all
2. How familiar are you with academic resources on campus? (Select all that apply)
 - ☐ Tutoring
 - ☐ Writing Center
 - ☐ Speech Lab
 - ☐ Facility Office Hours
3. How comfortable are you asking professors for academic support?
 - ☐ Very comfortable
 - ☐ Somewhat comfortable
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat uncomfortable
 - ☐ Not comfortable at all
4. How comfortable are you asking advisors for academic support?
 - ☐ Very comfortable
 - ☐ Somewhat comfortable
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat uncomfortable
 - ☐ Not comfortable at all
- 5.
6. How comfortable do you feel interacting with non-veteran students in academic or social settings on campus?
 - ☐ Very comfortable
 - ☐ Somewhat comfortable
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat uncomfortable
 - ☐ Not comfortable at all

7. How confident are you in managing stress related to school?
 - Very confident
 - Somewhat confident
 - Neutral
 - Somewhat unconfident
 - Not confident at all
8. Are you aware of mental health and counseling services available to student veterans on campus, and would you feel comfortable using them if needed?
 - Yes, I am aware and would feel comfortable using them
 - Yes, I am aware but not feel comfortable using them
 - No, I am not aware but would use them if needed
 - No, I am not aware and would not use them
9. How often do you feel imposter syndrome (feeling like you do not belong in college)?
 - Frequently
 - Sometimes
 - Rarely
 - Never
10. What are your biggest concerns about transitioning to college?
11. What do you hope to gain from this course?

Appendix C

Post-Survey

This appendix consists of the post survey that will be completed by veteran students who successfully complete the course. This survey will assess student veterans' progress in academic confidence, social integration, and awareness of available resources.

1. How confident do you feel about your ability to succeed academically?
 - ☐ Very confident
 - ☐ Somewhat confident
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat unconfident
 - ☐ Not confident at all
2. How familiar are you with academic resources on campus (e.g. tutoring, writing center, faculty office hours)?
 - ☐ Very familiar
 - ☐ Somewhat familiar
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat unfamiliar
 - ☐ Not familiar at all
3. How comfortable are you asking professors for academic support?
 - ☐ Very confident
 - ☐ Somewhat confident
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat unconfident
 - ☐ Not confident at all
4. How comfortable are you asking advisors for academic support?
 - ☐ Very confident
 - ☐ Somewhat confident
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat unconfident
 - ☐ Not confident at all
5. How comfortable do you feel interacting with non-veteran students?
 - ☐ Very comfortable
 - ☐ Somewhat comfortable
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat uncomfortable
 - ☐ Not comfortable at all

6. How do you currently manage stress in your academic or personal life? (Select all that apply)
 - ☐ Exercise or physical activity
 - ☐ Meditation or mindfulness practices
 - ☐ Talking to friends or family
 - ☐ Time management or organizational strategies
 - ☐ Seeking support from counseling or mental health services
 - ☐ Hobbies or creative outlets (e.g., art, music, writing)
 - ☐ Other (please specify)
7. Have you used any of the mental health and counseling services available to student veterans? (Yes/No)
8. How often do you feel imposter syndrome (feeling like you do not belong in college)?
 - ☐ Frequently
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
9. What was the most valuable aspect of this course?
10. What could be improved in future versions of this course?
11. Do you feel more prepared to navigate college life as a student veteran? (Yes/No)

Appendix D

Follow-up Survey

This follow-up survey assesses the long-term impact of this course on student veterans' academic success, social integration, and mental well-being three months after course completion. The results will help determine whether participants continue to use the skills and resources introduced in the course and identify areas for improvement.

1. Since completing the class, how confident do you feel in your ability to succeed academically?
 - ☐ Very confident
 - ☐ Somewhat confident
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Somewhat unconfident
 - ☐ Not confident at all
2. Have you used any of the academic resources introduced in the course? (Select all that apply)
 - ☐ Tutoring
 - ☐ Writing Center
 - ☐ Faculty Office Hours
 - ☐ Speech Lab
 - ☐ Other (please specify)
3. Have you addressed any academic challenges you have encountered since completing the course?
4. How connected do you feel to the campus community compared to when you first started college?
 - ☐ Much more connected
 - ☐ Somewhat more connected
 - ☐ No change
 - ☐ Somewhat less connected
 - ☐ Much less connected
5. Have you maintained any connections with other student veterans or support networks introduced in the course?
 - ☐ Yes, I regularly engage with them
 - ☐ Yes, but only occasionally
 - ☐ No, but I would like to
 - ☐ No, I do not find them necessary
6. Have you participated in any campus organizations or social events since completing the course? (Check all that apply)

- Study groups or academic clubs
 - Career development events (e.g., networking events, job fairs, resume workshops)
 - Service-learning or volunteer programs
 - Recreational or social groups
 - Community outreach or advocacy groups
 - Other (please specify): _____
- 7. Since completing the course, how confident are you in managing stress and balancing school, work, and personal life?
 - Very confident
 - Somewhat confident
 - Neutral
 - Somewhat unconfident
 - Not confident at all
- 8. How do you currently manage stress in your academic or personal life? (Select all that apply)
 - Exercise or physical activity
 - Meditation or mindfulness practices
 - Talking to friends or family
 - Time management or organizational strategies
 - Seeking support from counseling or mental health services
 - Hobbies or creative outlets (e.g., art, music, writing)
 - Other (please specify)
- 9. Have you utilized any of the mental health resources introduced in the course (e.g., counseling services, mindfulness strategies)?
 - Yes, frequently
 - Yes, occasionally
 - No, but I plan to
 - No, I do not feel the need
- 10. Have you used any financial planning strategies discussed in the course, such as managing GI Bill benefits or creating a personal budget?
 - Yes, frequently
 - Yes, occasionally
 - No, but I plan to
 - No, I have not needed to
- 11. Overall, how helpful was this course in supporting your college transition?
 - Extremely helpful
 - Somewhat helpful
 - Neutral
 - Somewhat unhelpful
 - Not helpful at all

12. What aspects of the course have been the most useful to you in the past three months?
13. Are there any additional resources or support services that would have been beneficial to you after completing the course?
14. In what ways has this course enhanced your transition to the institution?